Special Olympics

Overview & Definition

Special Olympics is the world's largest sports organization dedicated to empowering children and adults with intellectual disabilities through year-round athletic training and competitive events.



Special Olympics provides people with intellectual disabilities continuous opportunities to develop physical fitness, demonstrate courage, experience joy, and share skills and friendship with their families, other athletes, and the community.

Unlike the Paralympics (which focus primarily on physical disabilities), Special Olympics specifically supports athletes with intellectual disabilities across all skill levels.

History & Origin

The Special Olympics began in the 1960s through the advocacy of **Eunice Kennedy Shriver**, who sought to create equal athletic opportunities for individuals with intellectual disabilities.



Personal Inspiration (1950s):

Inspired by her sister Rosemary Kennedy, who had an intellectual disability, Eunice Kennedy Shriver observed that society routinely isolated people with cognitive differences and denied them access to sports and physical activities.

Camp Shriver Launched (June 1962)

Shriver started a free summer day camp at her farm in Timberlawn, Maryland. Camp Shriver allowed children with intellectual disabilities to participate in swimming, track, basketball, and horseback riding, proving that athletes with intellectual disabilities were far more capable than prevailing medical assumptions suggested.

First International Special Olympics World Games (July 20, 1968)

Co-organized by Shriver and Chicago park instructor Anne McGlone Burke, the first World Games took place at Soldier Field in Chicago, Illinois. Approximately 1,000 athletes from the United States and Canada competed across track and field, swimming, and floor hockey events.

Official Incorporation (December 1968)

Special Olympics was formally incorporated as a global non-profit organization, laying the groundwork for international program growth and standardized rules.

First Winter World Games (February 1977)

The movement expanded to winter sports with the inaugural Special Olympics World Winter Games in Steamboat Springs, Colorado.

Official IOC Recognition (February 1988)

The International Olympic Committee (IOC) signed a historic protocol formally recognizing Special Olympics and granting it official permission to use the name "Olympics."

The primary governing body of the global Special Olympics movement is **Special Olympics International (SOI)**. Headquartered in Washington, D.C., USA, SOI sets global policy, manages brand guidelines, oversees international competitions (including the Special Olympics World Games), and coordinates regional and national accreditation.

Governing Body

Governance Structure

1. Board of Directors

The **Board of Directors** serves as the ultimate governing authority of Special Olympics International. It determines global policy and consists of athletes, business executives, educators, professional athletes, and experts in intellectual disabilities.

- **Chairman of the Board:** Dr. Timothy Shriver
- **President & CEO:** David Evangelista

2. Regional Leadership Councils

SOI operates through seven geographic regions to manage day-to-day operations and regional development:

- Africa
- Asia-Pacific
- East Asia
- Europe/Eurasia
- Latin America
- Middle East/North Africa
- North America

3. Accredited National Programs

At the local level, individual country programs (e.g., Special Olympics Bharat, Special Olympics Canada, Special Olympics Great Britain) operate under official accreditation granted by SOI. Each national program follows SOI's General Rules while tailoring initiatives to local athlete communities.

Relationship with Other International Sports Bodies

- **International Olympic Committee (IOC):** The IOC formally recognized Special Olympics International in 1988. It is one of only three sporting organizations in the world officially authorized by the IOC to use the word *"Olympics"*. However, SOI operates completely independently of the IOC in terms of governance, finances, and event execution.
- **International Paralympic Committee (IPC):** Special Olympics is a separate entity from the IPC. While the Paralympics cater primarily to athletes with physical disabilities, Special Olympics focuses specifically on individuals with intellectual disabilities.

Eligibility Criteria

To participate as an athlete in Special Olympics, individuals must satisfy criteria related to diagnosis, age, and registration.

Primary Eligibility Criteria

1. Intellectual or Developmental Disability Requirement

An athlete must be identified by an agency or qualified professional as having an **intellectual disability** or a closely related **developmental disability**. This means meeting one or more of the following conditions:

- **Intellectual Functioning:** General intellectual functioning (IQ level) below 70–75.
- **Adaptive Functioning:** Significant limitations in adaptive skills required for everyday living (such as communication, self-care, social skills, health, or independent living).
- **Onset:** The condition typically manifests before the age of 18.

2. Age Requirements

- **Official Sports Competition:** Athletes must be at least **8 years old** to participate in official Special Olympics training and competitive events.
- **Young Athletes Program:** Children aged **2 to 7** can participate in early childhood play and sports development programs.
- **No Upper Age Limit:** There is **no maximum age limit**; athletes can continue to train and compete throughout adulthood.

Non-Eligible Conditions Alone

Individuals whose functional limitations are **solely** based on the following are *not* eligible to participate as Special Olympics athletes (though they may participate as Unified Partners or volunteers):

- Physical disabilities alone (without an accompanying intellectual disability)
- Emotional or behavioral disorders
- Specific learning disabilities (such as dyslexia or ADHD)
- Sensory impairments (e.g., blindness or hearing loss alone)

Registration Requirements

To compete, athletes must submit:

1. An official **Athlete Registration & Medical Form** signed by a licensed medical practitioner.
2. Verification of eligibility provided by a qualified healthcare professional, educator, or social worker.

The Special Olympics athlete oath acts as the official motto of the movement, while its overarching aim centers on lifelong empowerment through sports.

Motto, Aim & Oath

1. The Oath & Motto

"Let me win. But if I cannot win, let me be brave in the attempt."

Written and spoken by founder Eunice Kennedy Shriver at the opening ceremony of the first Special Olympics World Games in Chicago on July 20, 1968, this statement serves as both the athletic oath recited at all competitions and the central motto of the organization.

2. The Aim (Mission Statement)

The primary aim of Special Olympics is to provide year-round sports training and athletic competition in a wide variety of Olympic-type sports for children and adults with intellectual disabilities.

Core Objectives:

- **Physical Fitness:** Develop physical health, motor skills, and athletic capability.
- **Personal Growth:** Provide opportunities to demonstrate courage, build confidence, and experience accomplishment.
- **Social Inclusion:** Foster lifelong friendships, teamwork, and integration among athletes, families, and the broader community.

Symbol, Flag & Flame / Torch Relay

The Symbol



Origin: Created in 1979 based on a sculpture titled *"Joy and Happiness to All the Children of the World"* by artist Zurab Tsereteli.

Visual Elements: Features five stylized human figures in a circular formation with arms in different positions (downward, straight, and raised).

Symbolic Meaning:

- **Downward & straight arms:** Represent equality, outreach, and meeting athletes where they begin.
- **Raised arms:** Represent joy, growth, confidence, and achievement.
- **Circular shape:** Symbolizes international unity, global inclusion, and a shared space without barriers.

The Official Flag

- **Design:** Features the red Special Olympics symbol alongside the official logotype, typically displayed on a solid white banner (or white symbol on a red background).
- **Protocol:** Raised alongside the Olympic flag and host country flag during the Opening Ceremonies of local, regional, and World Games.
- **Meaning:** Represents peace, sportsmanship, and international solidarity across member programs in over 190 countries.

Flame of Hope & Law Enforcement Torch Run (LETR)

- **Lighting Ceremony:** Ignited in Athens, Greece, using sunlight reflected off parabolic mirrors in a ceremony similar to the traditional Olympic flame lighting.
- **Law Enforcement Torch Run (LETR):** Law enforcement officers and Special Olympics athletes, acting as *"Guardians of the Flame"*, carry the torch across host countries leading up to major games.
- **Opening Ceremony:** The relay ends at the Opening Ceremony when the final torch bearer lights the main cauldron to signal the official start of the competition.

Major Events & Sports Included

Special Olympics offers over 30 Olympic-style individual and team sports, providing year-round training and competition opportunities worldwide.

Major International Events

Special Olympics competitions operate at local, regional, national, and world levels. The showcase events are:

- **Special Olympics World Summer Games:** Held every four years, gathering thousands of athletes from over 190 countries competing in high-level summer sports.
- **Special Olympics World Winter Games:** Held every four years (alternating every two years with the Summer Games), focusing on snow and ice sports.
- **Special Olympics USA Games / Regional Games:** Large-scale competitions organized by geographic regions (such as Asia-Pacific Games, European Games, or USA Games) during non-World-Game years.

Sports Offered

Official Summer Sports

- **Athletics (Track & Field)**
- **Aquatics (Swimming)**
- **Basketball (including 3x3)**
- **Bocce**
- **Bowling**
- **Cycling**
- **Equestrian**
- **Football (Soccer) / Futsal**
- **Golf**
- **Gymnastics (Artistic & Rhythmic)**
- **Powerlifting**
- **Roller Skating**
- **Table Tennis & Badminton**
- **Tennis & Pickleball**
- **Volleyball & Beach Volleyball**

Official Winter Sports

- **Alpine Skiing**
- **Cross-Country Skiing**
- **Figure Skating**
- **Floor Hockey & Floorball**
- **Snowboarding**
- **Snowshoeing**
- **Speed Skating (Short Track)**

Frequency & Year Cycle

The **Special Olympics World Games** follow a **two-year cycle**, alternating between Summer and Winter Games every two years. Each specific type of Games (Summer or Winter) takes place on a **four-year cycle**.